



Spring 2019 Research Summit

Evaluating the Experiences and Perspectives of Peer Mentors Supporting
Students With Intellectual Disability in Inclusive Higher Education

 **ThinkCollege**
NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER



Think College National Coordinating Center is a project of the Institute for
Community Inclusion at UMass Boston, and is funded by the Office of
Postsecondary Education, US Dept. of Education. Grant # P407B100002

Today's presentations

Examining the Experiences and Expectations of
Peer Mentors: A Cross-Campus Study.

Erik Carter



Inclusive Higher Education at an Australian
University: Perspectives of Students with
Intellectual Disability and Their Mentors.

Fiona Rillotta





MOTIVATIONS, EXPECTATIONS, & EXPERIENCES OF PEER MENTORS WITHIN INCLUSIVE HIGHER EDUCATION PROGRAMS

Erik Carter
Vanderbilt University
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And many, many others

COLLABORATIVE CROSS-CAMPUS STUDIES

Studies

- Peer mentor surveys
- Peer mentor focus groups
- Faculty experiences survey
- Community conversation events
- And others in the future

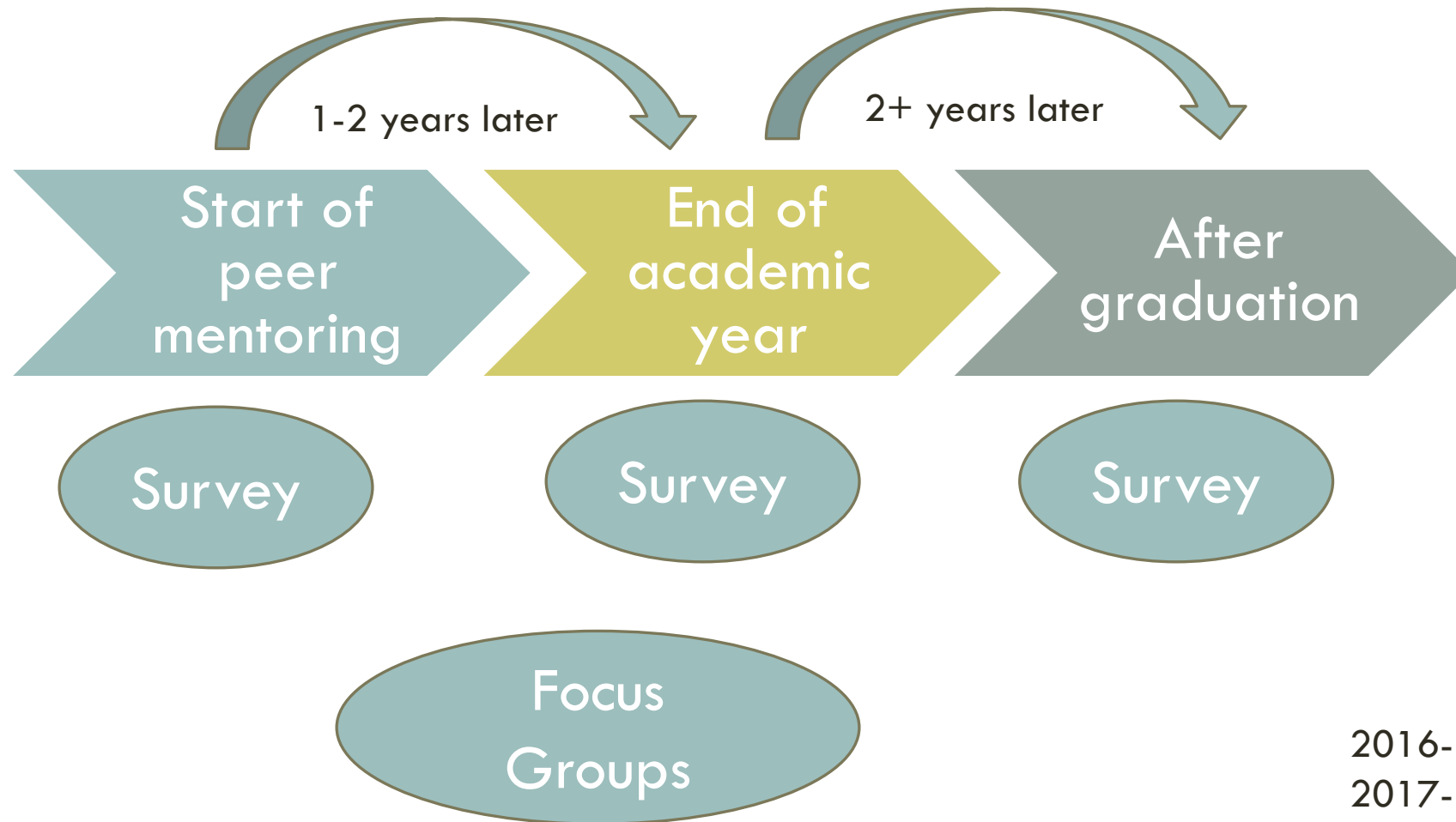
Campuses

- Lipscomb University
- Union University
- University of Memphis
- University of Tennessee
- Vanderbilt University



Erik W. Carter, Jenny R. Gustafson, Michael M. Mackay, Kaitlyn P. Martin, Misty V. Parsley, Jennifer Graves, Tammy L. Day, Lauren E. McCabe, Hannah Lazarz, Elise D. McMillan, Chrisann Schiro-Geist, Maurice Williams, Tom Beeson, & John Cayton

OVERALL DESIGN



2016-17 pre and post
2017-18 pre and post
2018-19 post only

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Survey: Start of Year

Who volunteers to serve as peer mentors?

What factors lead peer mentors to become involved in this campus opportunity?

What benefits do peer mentors anticipate will accrue to them?

What expectations do peer mentors hold for their peers with intellectual disability—both on campus and after graduation?

Survey: End of Academic Year

How do peer mentors view...

...the impact on students with ID?

...the impact on themselves?

...the impact on their campuses?

What type of contact do peer mentors anticipate having in the future?

What expectations do peer mentors hold for their peers with intellectual disability—both on campus and after graduation?

Focus Groups

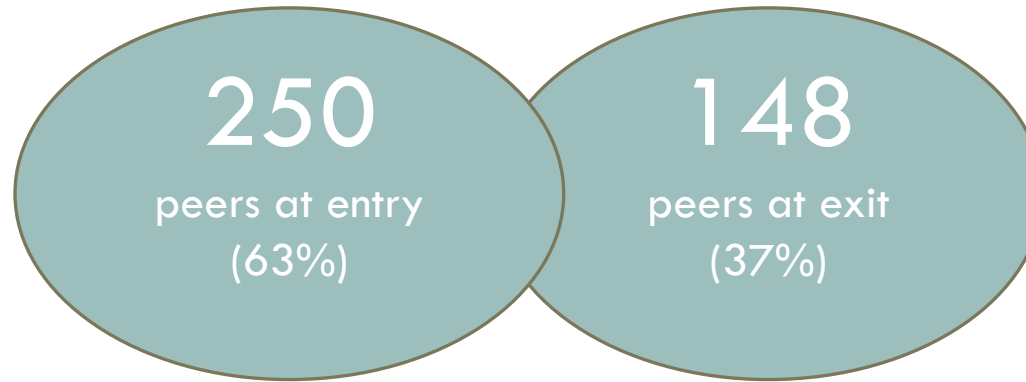
What factors lead peer mentors to become involved in this campus opportunity?

How do peer mentors characterize their experiences?

Who do peer mentors characterize their relationships with students with ID?

How do peer mentors describe the impact of IHE programs on themselves and their campuses?

PARTICIPANTS



Mean age 20.0 years ($SD = 2.0$; range, 17-40)

Nearly all (98.4%) were undergraduate students:

- 24.4% were freshmen
- 26.8% were sophomores
- 26.0% were juniors
- 21.2% were seniors

Grade point average (GPA) at semester start:

- 55.2% had a 3.5 to 4.0 GPA
- 29.2% had a 3.0 to 3.4 GPA
- 6.4% had a 2.5 to 2.9 GPA
- 2.4% had a 2.0 to 2.4 GPA
- 1.2% had less than a 2.0 GPA

Sex:

- 81.2% female
- 18.0% male
- 0.8% did not report

Race/ethnicity:

- 78.4% White
- 10.0% African American/Black
- 8.8% Asian American
- 4.4% Latina/Latina/Hispanic
- 2.8% American Indian or Alaska Native
- 0.4% Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander
- 1.2% were Other races/ethnicities.

OTHER CHARACTERISTICS

Most students (82.0%) had *neither* a major nor minor in the areas of education or special education.

A total of 78 different majors were represented, the most common major areas were:

- biological sciences (11.6%)
- special education (10.4%)
- business/marketing (7.6%)
- other education (elementary, teaching English as a second language; 7.6%)
- medicine/health care (7.2%)
- psychology (5.2%)
- social work (4.4%)

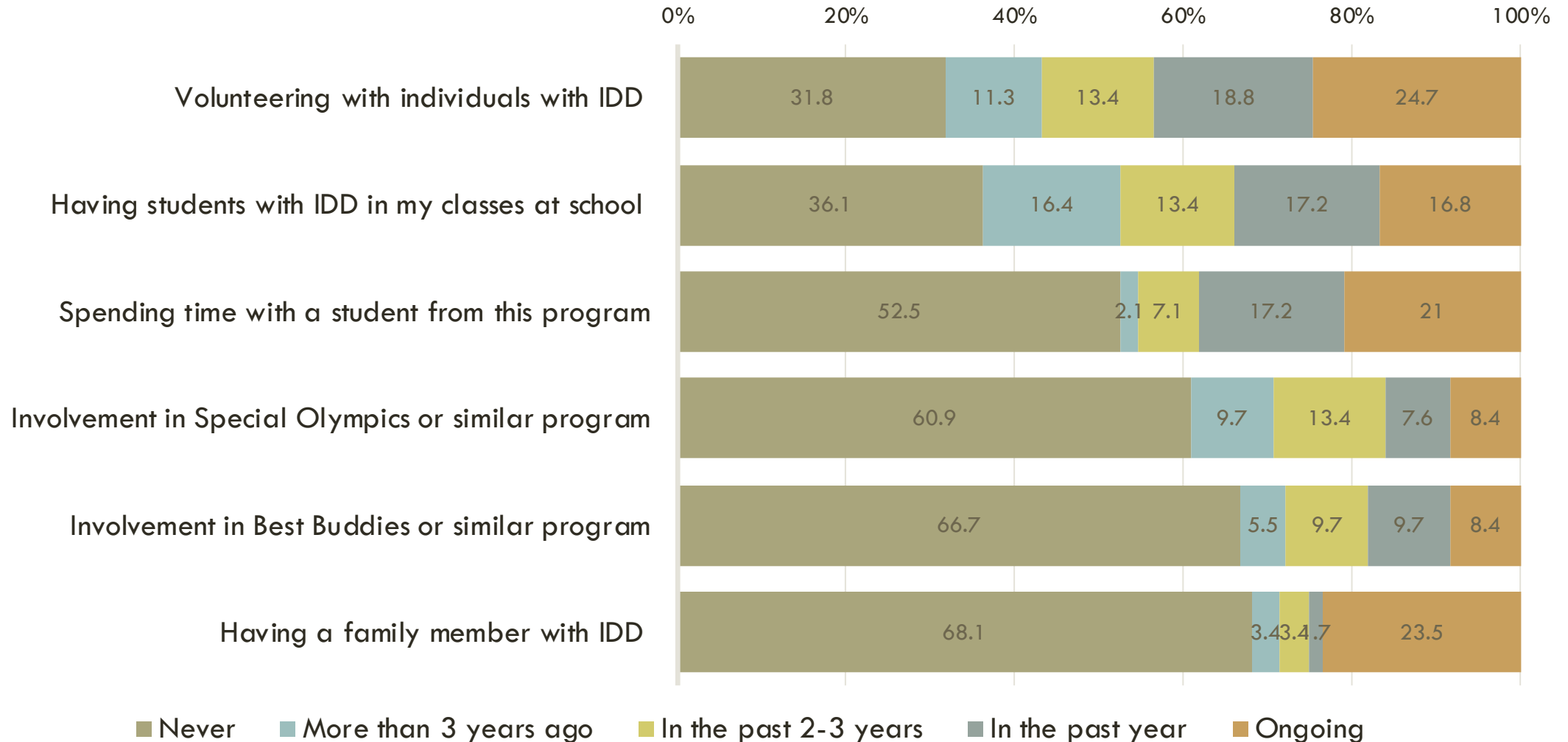


FINDINGS FROM INITIAL ENTRY

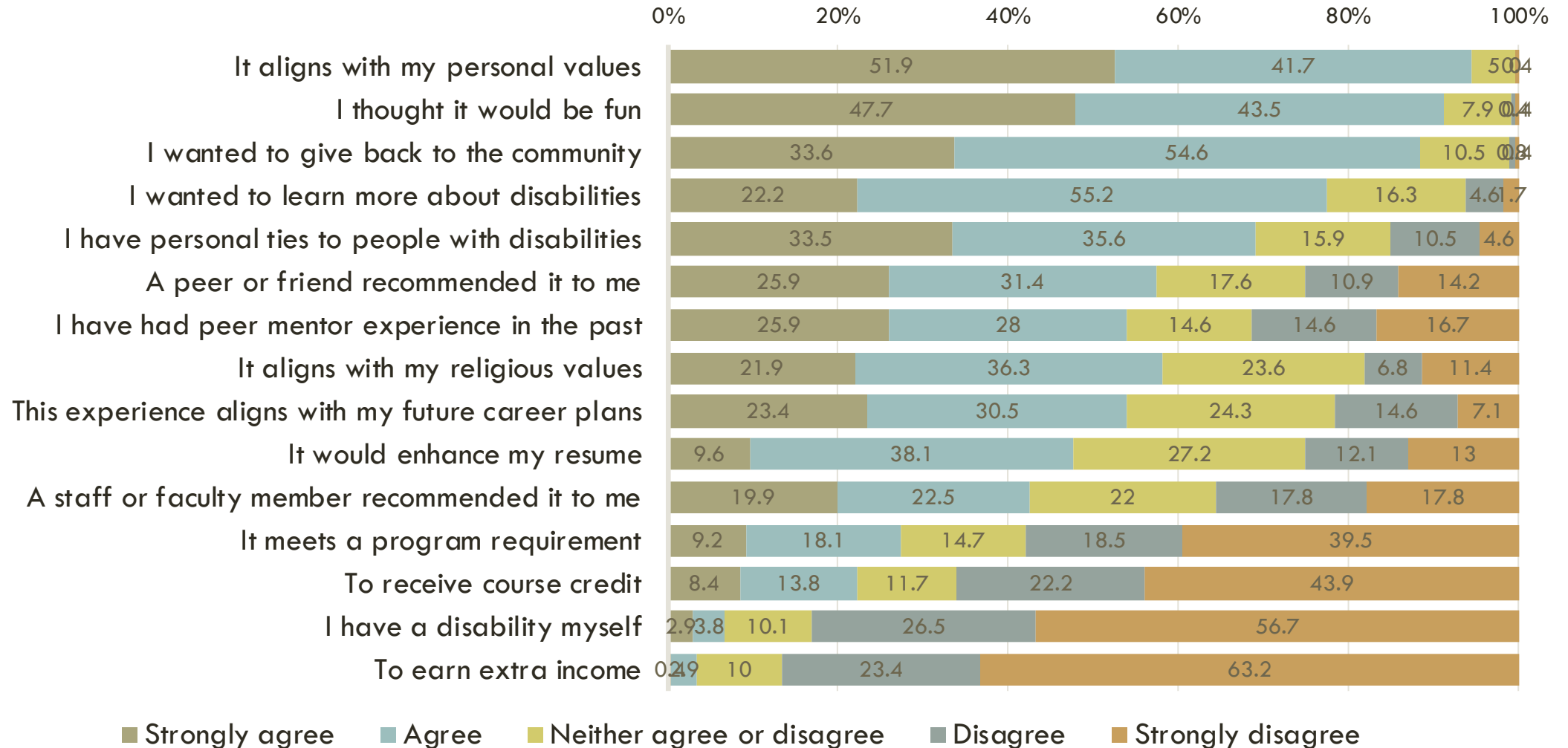
2016-2017

PRIOR EXPERIENCES

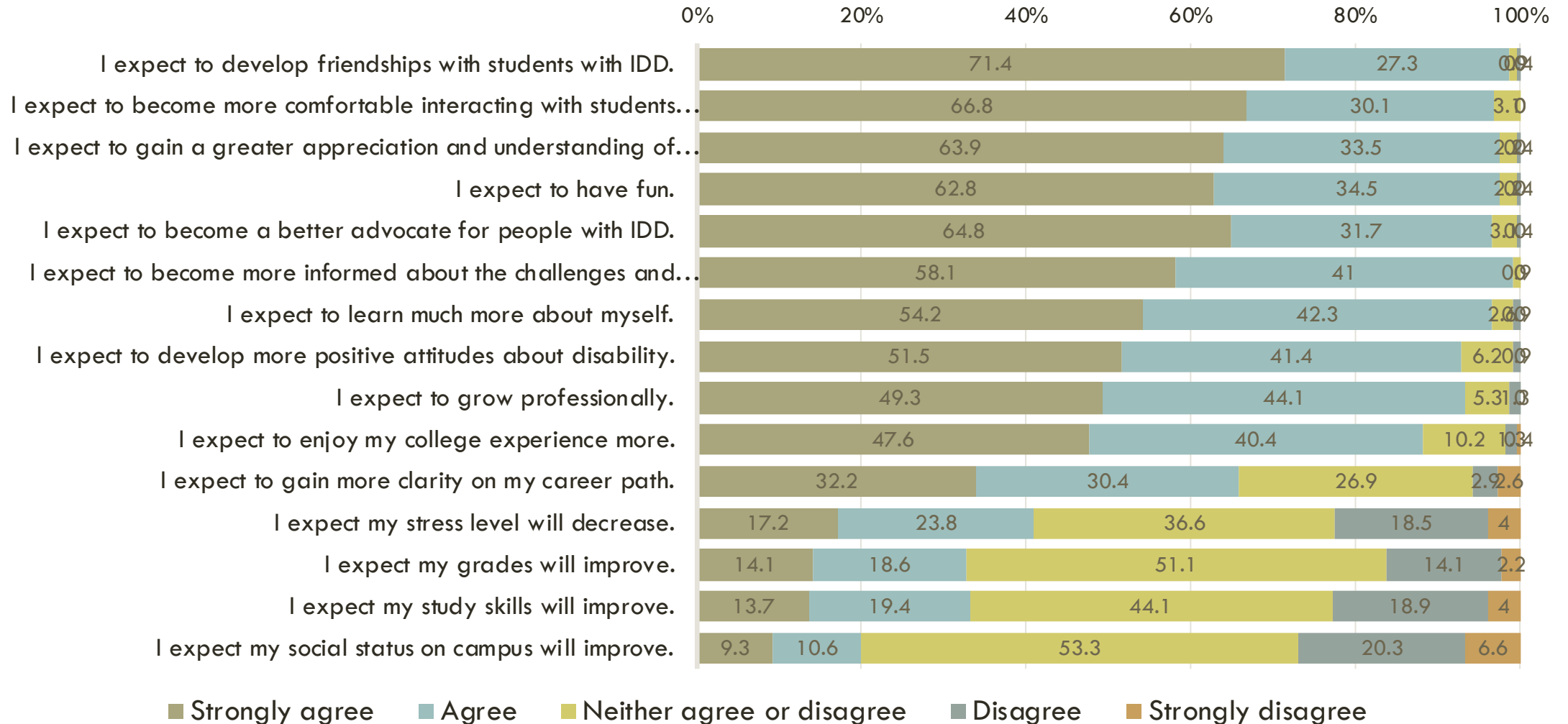
None of these experiences: 6.3%
 One of these experiences: 18.3%
 Two of these experiences: 17.9%
 Three of these experiences: 22.5%
 Four of these experiences: 16.7%
 Five of these experiences: 11.7%
 All of these experiences: 6.7%



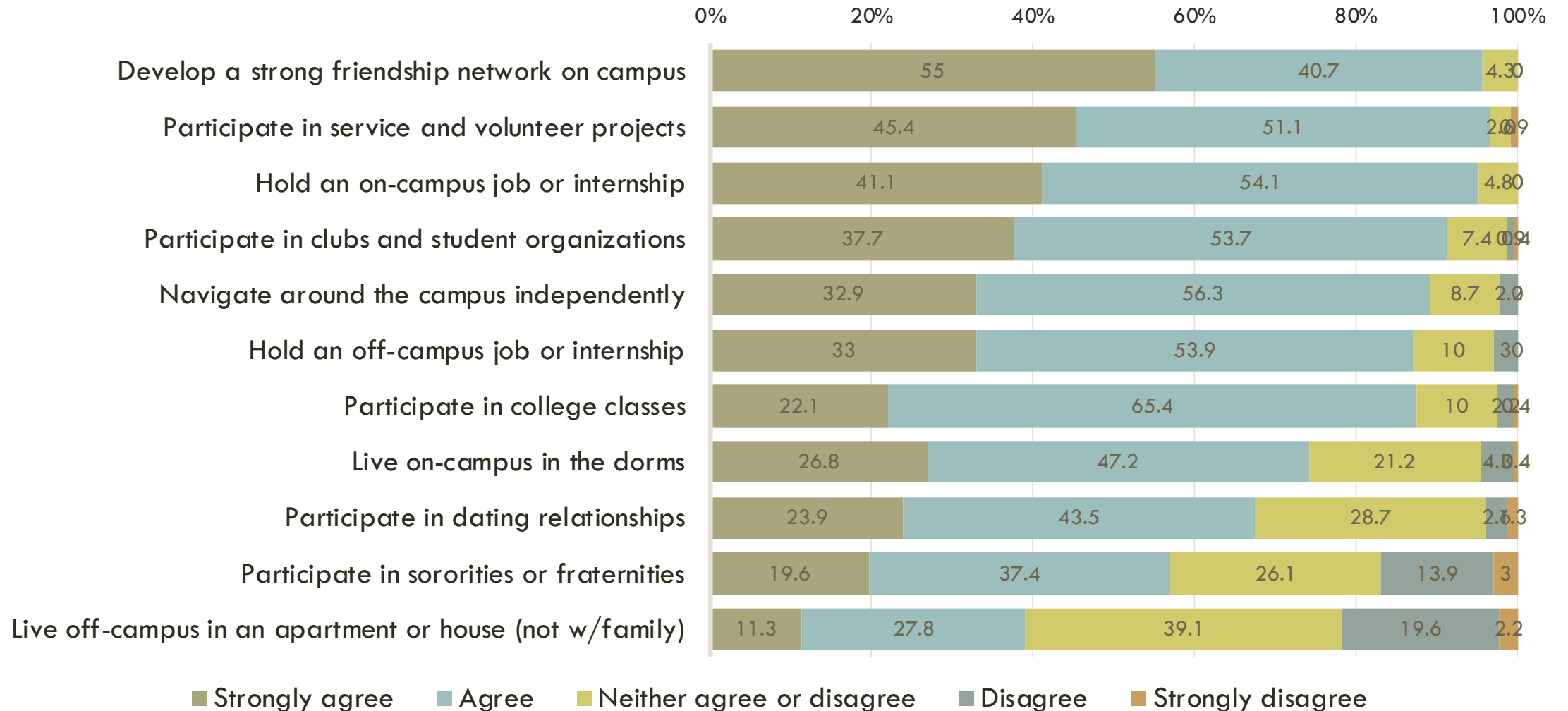
FACTORS LEADING TO INVOLVEMENT



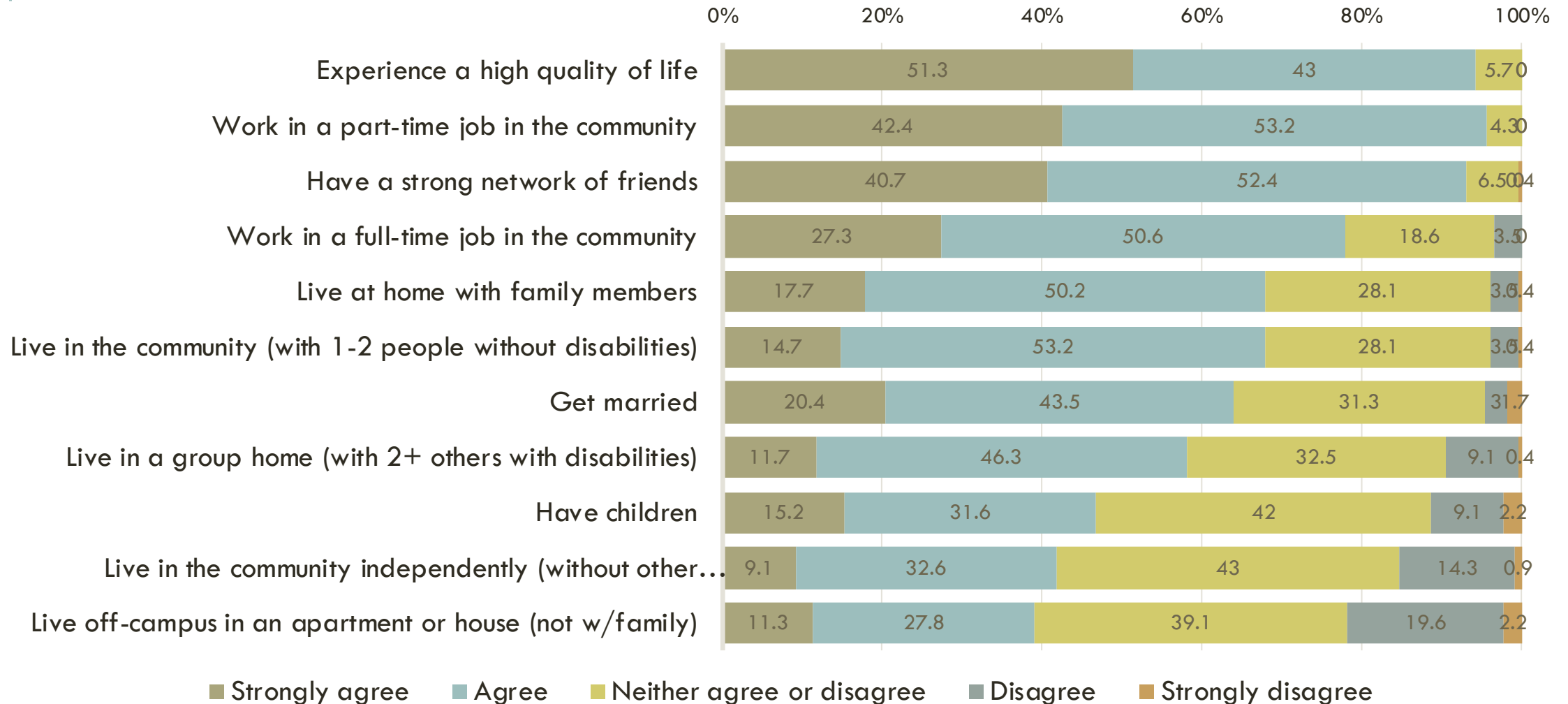
ANTICIPATED IMPACT



ON-CAMPUS EXPECTATIONS



POST-GRADUATION EXPECTATIONS

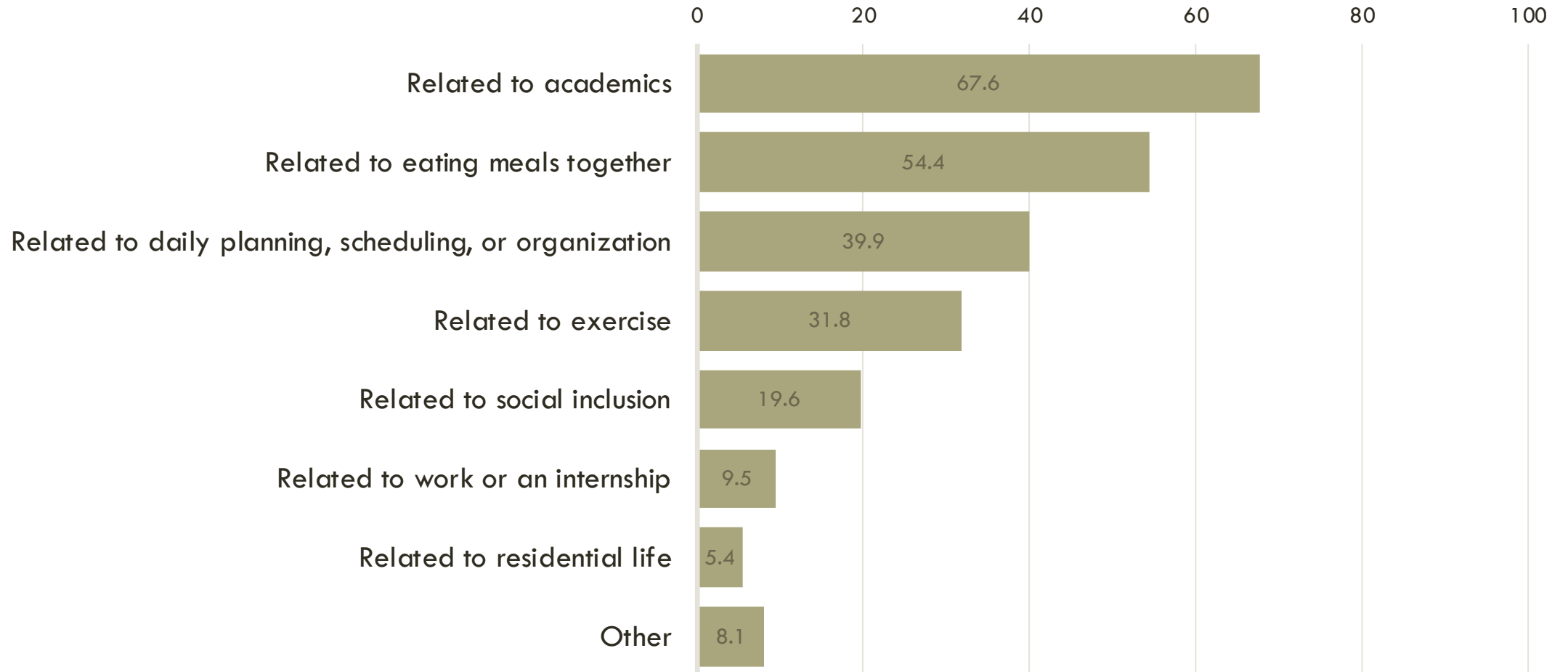




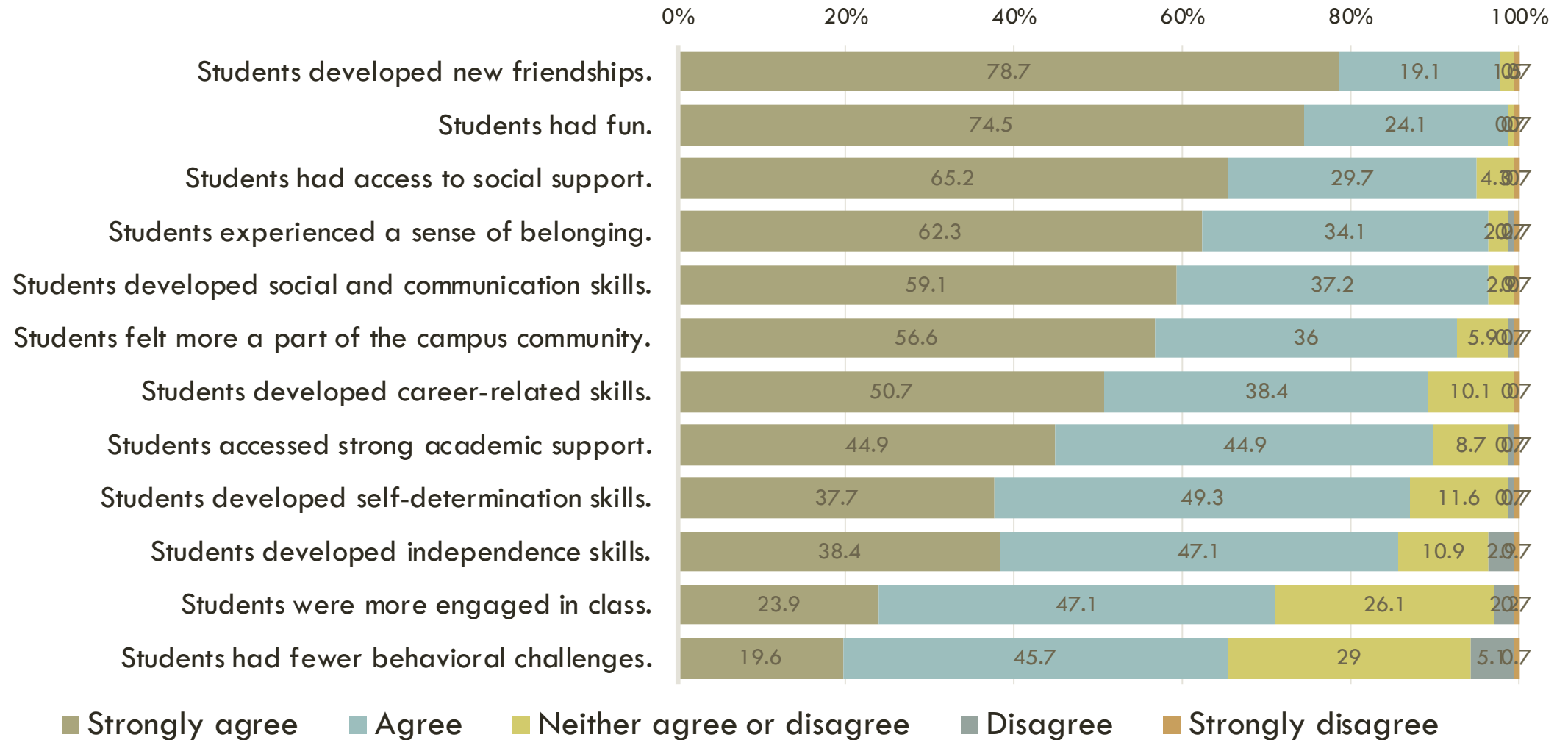
FINDINGS FROM END-OF-SEMESTER

2016-2017

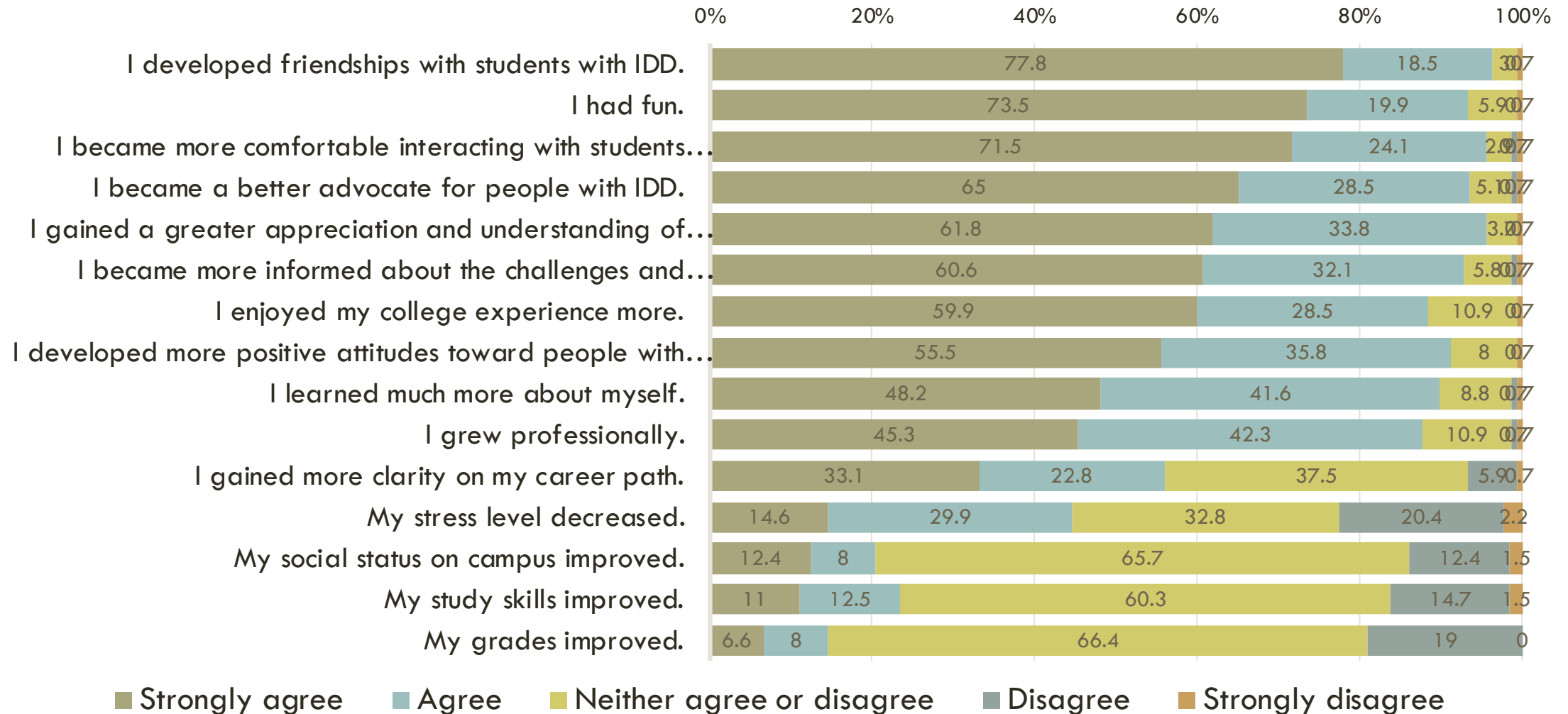
AREAS OF PEER SUPPORT



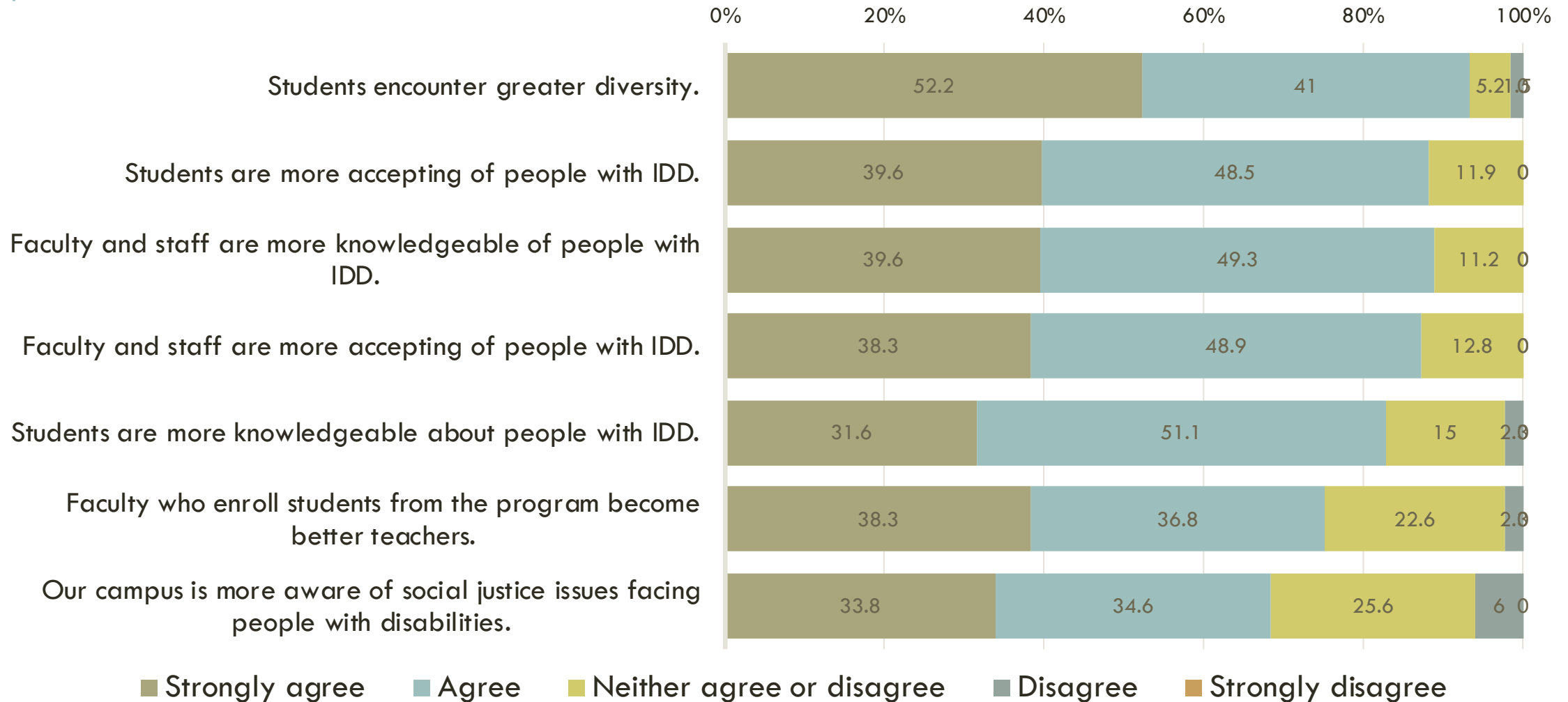
IMPACT ON STUDENTS WITH ID



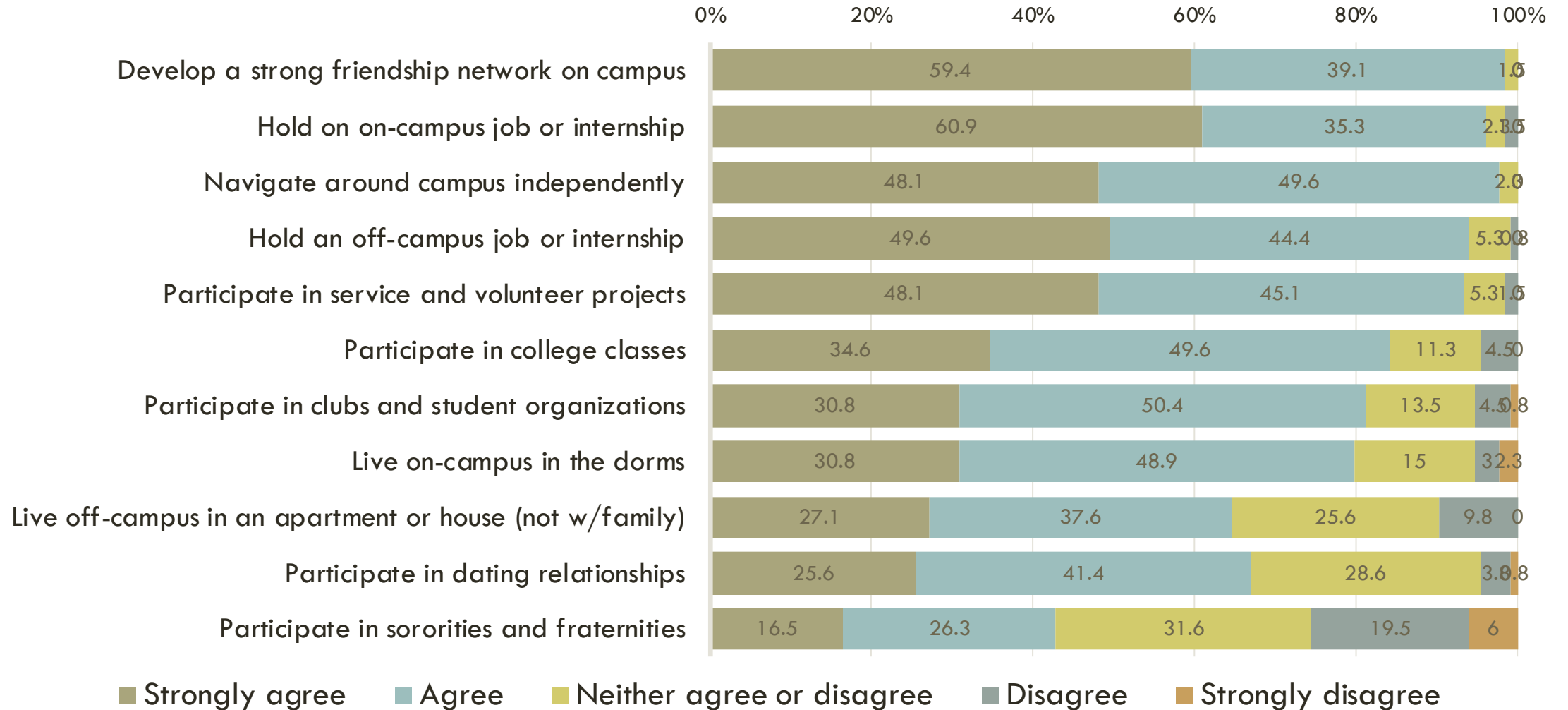
IMPACT ON PEER MENTORS



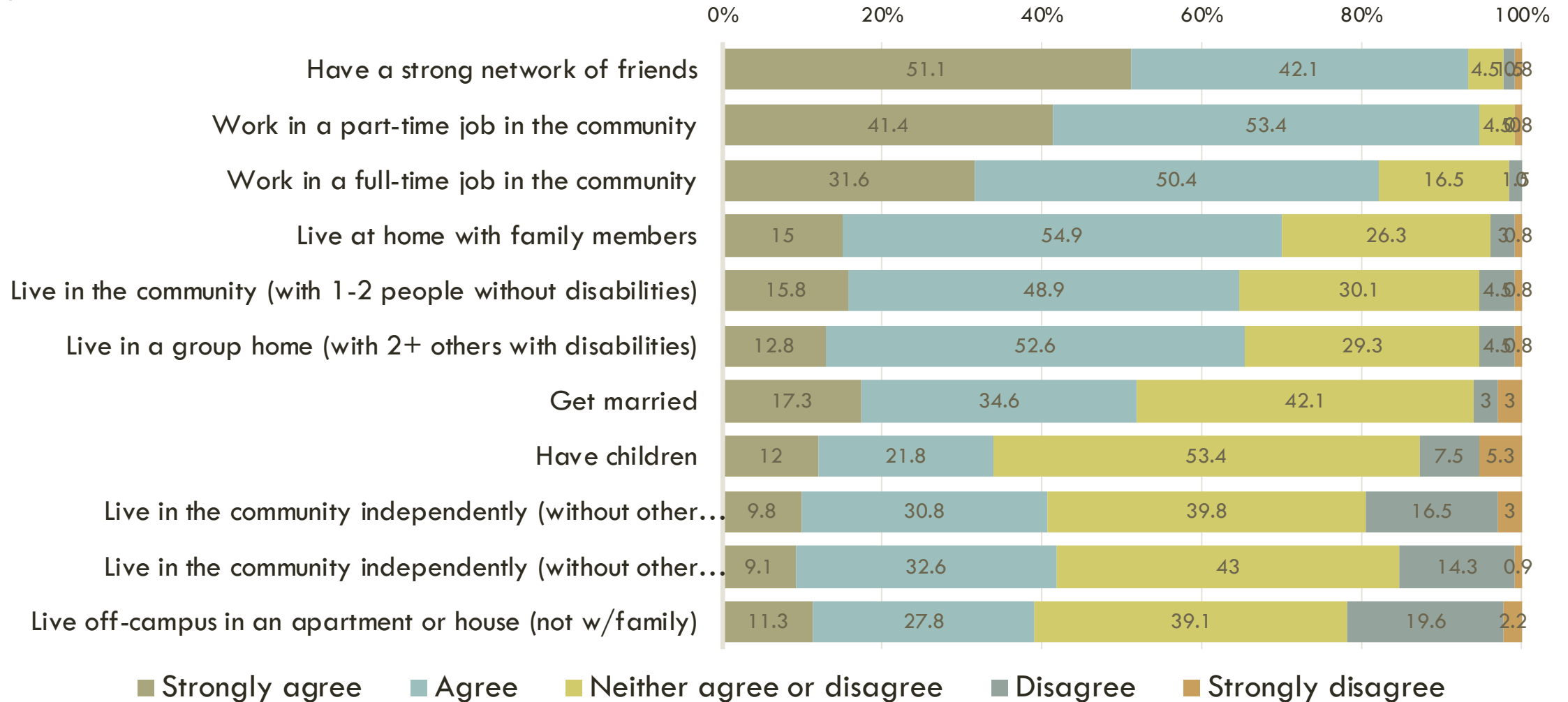
IMPACT ON CAMPUS



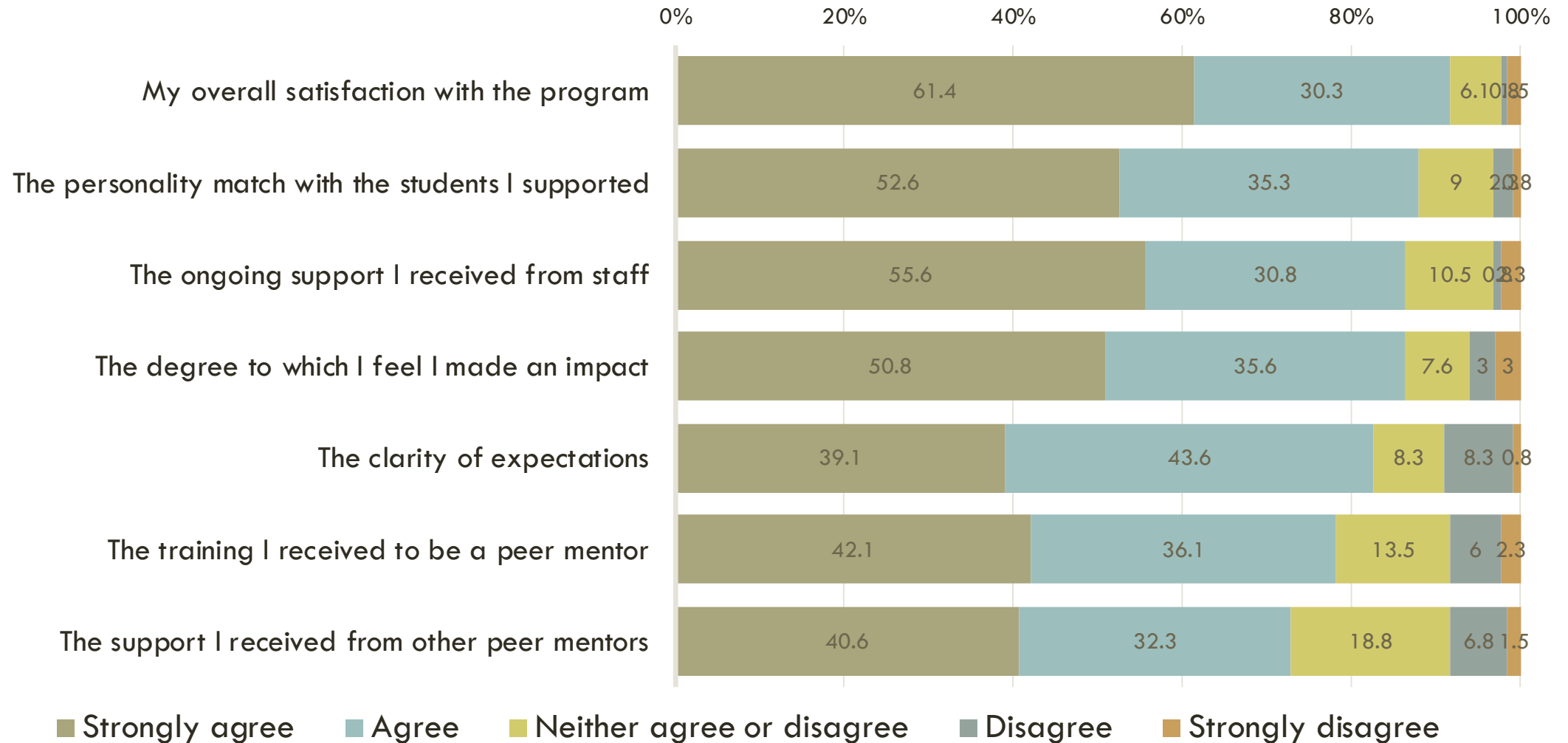
ON-CAMPUS EXPECTATIONS



POST-GRADUATION EXPECTATIONS

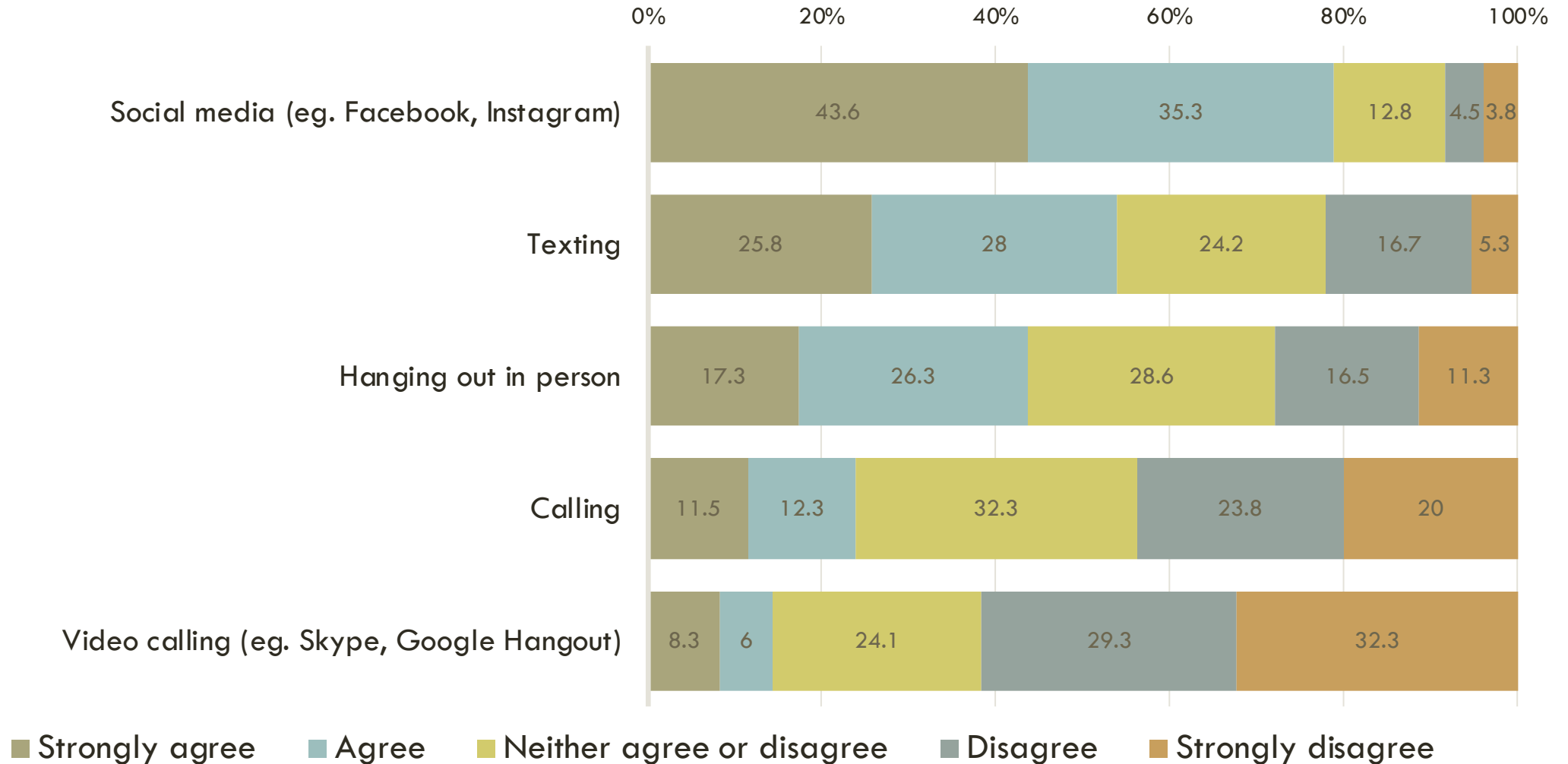


PEER MENTOR SATISFACTION



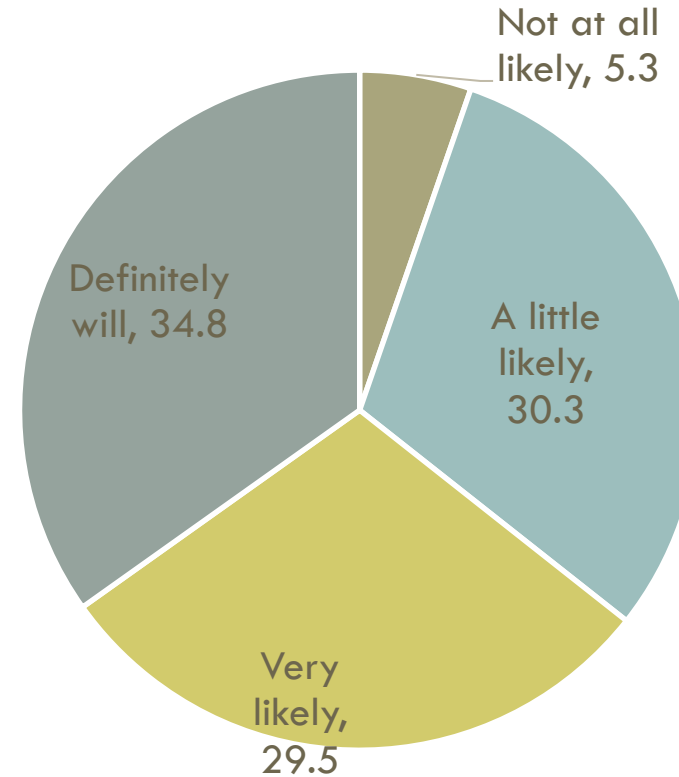
ANTICIPATED FUTURE CONTACT

To what extent will you stay in contact after graduation with the students whom you supported mostly closely this year?



PROFESSIONAL PLANS

To what extent do you anticipate your future career will somehow involve work with or advocacy on behalf of people with IDD?





WHERE WE GO NEXT?



Flinders
UNIVERSITY



Inclusive Higher Education at an Australian University: Perspectives of students with intellectual disability and their mentors

Rillotta, F., Arthur, J., Hutchinson, C., &
Raghavendra, P. (2018). Inclusive
university experience in Australia:
Perspectives of students with
intellectual disability and their mentors.
Journal of Intellectual Disabilities,
DOI: 10.1177/1744629518769421



This study investigated the expectations and experiences of students with ID in an inclusive individual support PSE programme in Australia through interviews with students and peer mentors.

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Lecturer & Honours Coordinator
Disability and Community Inclusion
College of Nursing and Health Sciences
Flinders University**

Acknowledgements

- The Up the Hill Project (UTHP), was previously funded by the Department for Communities and Social Inclusion (DCSI), Government of South Australia.
- Faculty of Medicine, Nursing & Health Sciences, Flinders University Establishment Grant.
- Co-authors – Jillian Arthur, Claire Hutchinson, Pammi Raghavendra
- Jenny Widdop & Lorraine Lindsay
- Research participants for their time to share their experience.

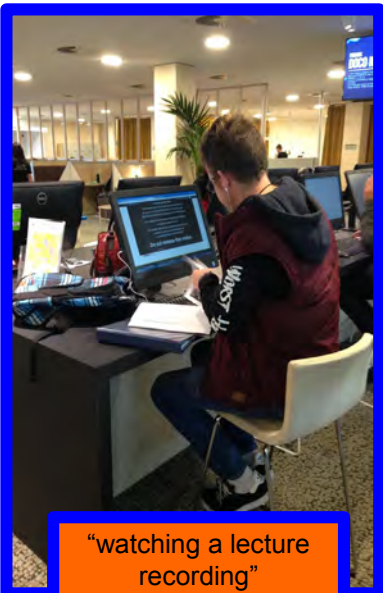


Philosophy of Inclusive Higher Education

*“By **deliberately and consciously** embedding [people] with ID within these typical pathways, by facilitating their **full inclusion over time**, by holding **high expectations**, by pursuing **IPSE and a career**, good lives are more likely realized.”*

(Uditsky and Hughson, 2012, p.299)

Persons with disabilities have the same rights to equality... in the area of education as the rest of the community



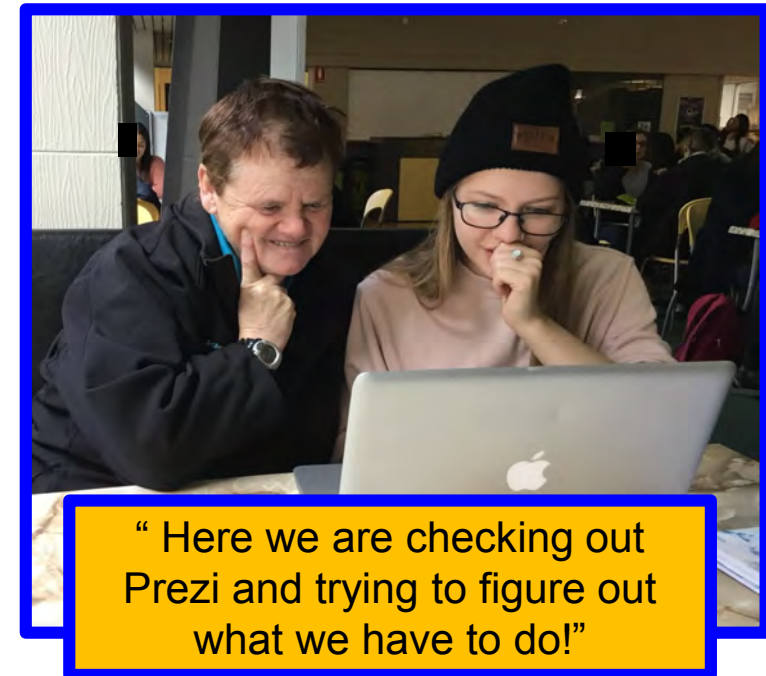
“watching a lecture recording”
in Flinders Connect.



“ I felt happy and focused!”

Models of Post-Secondary Education

- **Mixed or hybrid** - ‘dual enrolment’ - attend some inclusive higher education classes for credit or auditing, while also completing high school curriculum in segregated classes (with other students with ID).
- **Substantially separate** - conducted on college campuses but focus on life skills, social skills and work readiness rather than academic goals.
- **Inclusive individual support** - *students receive individualised services (e.g. educational coach, tutor, peer mentors, natural supports) to access college courses, certificate programs, and/or degree programs, for audit or credit.*



Where is Flinders?

Why “Up the Hill”?

inspiring achievement





<https://www.flinders.edu.au/engage/community/clinics/up-the-hill-project>

the
Up the Hill
project

Self-determination & Social Inclusion

- Mentors support students to identify goals and review goals each semester.
- Students work with peer mentors to identify the objectives required to meet their goals.
- Making friendships and being included requires self-determination skills.
- Mentors model social skills.
- Role-playing & practising these skills naturally.
- Presentations, social gatherings, class discussions.



Recognition of Achievement

- At the end of each semester all the students and their families get together for a presentation day.
- Students are invited to present on the topics undertaken that semester.
- Certificate of attendance.
- After three years students receive a certificate of achievement at the main University graduation ceremony with the students who have been their mentors.



The Role of Peer Mentors

- Mentors support the auditing student
 - enrol in topics and obtain their student identity card and access to library and computer facilities.
 - with orientation by providing a familiarisation tour of the campus and surrounding areas.
 - meet lecturers prior to the commencement of classes and facilitate any modifications required for inclusion in the lecture.



Previous Research

- Participation in university can have positive personal, social, and academic outcomes.
- People with intellectual disability (N=14 from two studies) who audited topics reported feeling more **independent**, feeling **better about themselves**, enjoyed **meeting different people**, and **learning about different topics**. (Gibson, 1997; Lobban, 2002)
- Mentoring **partnership** (teaching students and students with ID) – early exposure, meaningful interactions, collaborative relationships – can positively influence awareness and attitudes toward inclusive practices (Jones & Goble, 2012)
- Little research evidence within Australia about the benefits of inclusive higher education for people with intellectual disability

Research Question & Aims

What are the experiences of participating in an Australian inclusive university program for students with intellectual disability?

Aims:

- 1) To investigate the expectations and experiences of auditing students with ID participating in an Australian inclusive university program
- 2) To explore mentors' perceptions and opinions of the university experience for auditing students with ID participating in an Australian inclusive university program .

Methods

- N = 10 (4 students; 6 mentors)
- Qualitative
- Semi-structured interviews at two time points
 - start of semester (expectations)
 - end of semester (experiences)
- Thematic Analysis (Braun, & Clarke, 2006)



Student Interview Questions

- Questions related to:
 - self-confidence/ self-determination
 - decision to come to university
 - hopes/ goals for semester
 - mentoring relationships
 - expectations met/ goal attainment
 - likes/ dislikes of attending university



Mentor Interview Questions

- Questions related to:
 - Predicted outcomes for student with ID
 - Inclusive practices by teaching staff and peers
 - Positive aspects/ challenges of mentoring experience
 - Opinions of outcomes for student with ID



Results – Themes and Subthemes

Self Determination

“...even though... within the project we are their mentors, they are actually quite capable of doing things by them... selves, yes” (Mentor 1).

Social Development

‘me and [student’s name] built a strong friendship so like I kind of just see her as a friend, a really close friend... we will still catch up...’ (Mentor 1).

Inclusive Practices

“... they [other students] all went into the reading groups and we weren’t allowed in one because they all presented... no one really wanted us there... we were kind of excluded” (Mentor 4).

Intellectual Development

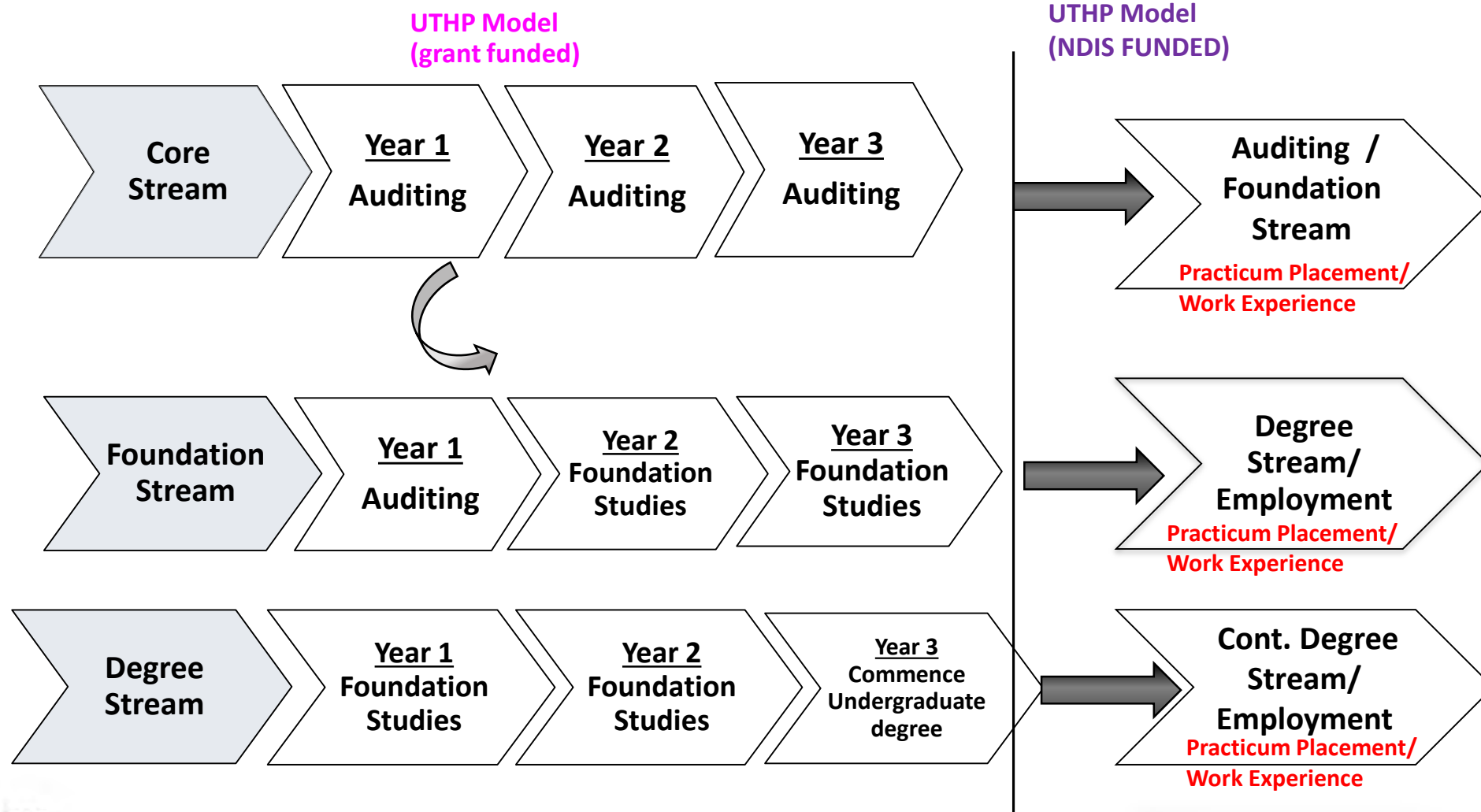
‘...she wanted the academic side of it so she wanted to do all of the assignments and quizzes’ (Mentor 2)

Recommendations

- Education for university Lecturers about inclusive practices (to support inclusion of students with intellectual disability).
- Further knowledge and understanding of the capabilities of people with ID, and about inclusive practices is required for the broader university community.
- **Students with ID should be supported to undertake formal university qualifications/ degrees**

Future Plans for UTHP

Proposed changes to UTHP Model



Future Research

- Lecturers' attitudes and perspectives about having people with an intellectual disability in their class.
- Post UTHP transition - follow up outcomes for students over the last decade (e.g. what are graduates doing now). Transition from higher education to employment (work experience, internships, practicums, placements)
- University student/ peer attitudes towards inclusive education for people with an intellectual disability.
- Employment skills gained from the practicum – transferable to work/ vocational/ occupational environment
- Longitudinal – prior to/ during/ after 3 years. Goal Attainment Scaling; Wehmeyer Self-Determination Scale
- Facilitators and barriers for students with ID to undertake formal university qualifications/ degrees

Conclusions

Australian policies legislate that people with (intellectual) disability have a right to study at any educational institution in the same way as any other student.

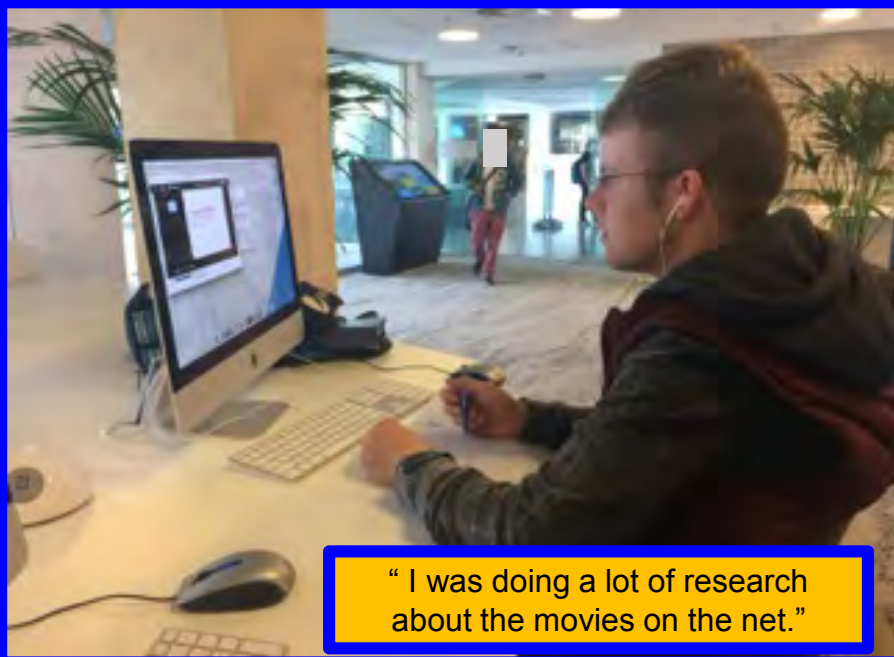


With **appropriate support**, people with intellectual disability develop personally, socially, and academically through meaningful involvement in inclusive university, including practicum placement experiences. *We still have a long way to go....*

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AMBITIOUS



"I was doing a lot of research about the movies on the net."



"On the way to our end of semester meeting at Sturt Campus."

INSPIRING



Questions

Please type in the chat box

Have you joined our Affinity Group on Research?

- Learn about research that is happening in the field of inclusive higher education
- Connect with other researchers and explore possible collaborations
 - Share tools and resources

Next meeting: Tuesday August 13th at 1pm Eastern

Interested in joining the Affinity Group on Research?

Visit www.thinkcollege.net to learn more

Click on Technical Assistance → Affinity Groups → Research Affinity Group

Have you joined the Conversation?

Join Think College
Conversations at
www.thinkcollege.net/convos

And once you're logged in, be
sure to join the #research
channel!

Think College has opened a forum to encourage the exchange of ideas, problem-solving, and resource sharing between individuals interested in inclusive post-secondary education. Using the Slack platform, we are able to categorize conversations by topic, share files and other information, and talk in groups or with individuals.

- Handouts: www.thinkcollege.net → Training → Research Summits
- Please make sure to complete the evaluation questions (in Zoom)
- Join us on Slack to continue the conversation in the #research channel
- Interested in presenting at a future Research Summit?
 - Send an email to clare.papay@umb.edu
- Don't miss our next webinar:
 - Creating Inclusive (Campus) Communities Begins in the Classroom. May 15th 1-2pm ET

Thank you for
joining us today!